

Headphones

Owning a set of cans is like getting a passport to the Kingdom of Audiophilia. But you can't just sport any old pair of headphones to be considered an initiated member of this clan. To gain the privilege of being a "serious" audiophile you need to know and own the right gear. And in this, an audiophile is always spoiled for choice. This year saw some pretty decent releases and some of the best managed to end up falling into our eager hands.

Zero1 Winner Sennheiser HD 800

The HD 800 is Sennheiser's latest flagship headphone replacing the good old HD 650. The HD 800 is a ticket to a stratospheric stereo experience – fairly neutral, with maybe a smidgeon more emphasis on the highs than the lows. Plus it will woo you with tonal accuracy and soundstage rather than cheap (read: boomy) thrills. The HD 800 is a performance monster and rightfully walks away with our Zero1 Award this year.

Full review: <http://bit.ly/senh800>

Worthy mention TDK WR700

Unlike most wireless headphones that downgrade the audio quality for easy transmission, the WR700 is lossless. This is achieved via a transmission technology called Kleer that uses the 2.4 GHz band for RF transmission of totally uncompressed audio. For wireless headphones, the performance is superlative. For someone looking for a wireless solution without compromising on sound quality, it makes for a perfect purchase.

Full review: <http://bit.ly/wr700tdk>



◀ HEADPHONES:
SENNHEISER HD 800
Price: ₹79,990



◀ HEADPHONES –
IN EARS: BRAINWAVZ M3
Price: ₹4,200



MEElectronics M6
Price: ₹1,400 (approx)



TDK WR700
Price: ₹6,900



Philips SHE 9750
Price: ₹1,999

IEMs

It wouldn't be too much of a stretch to call In Ear Monitors (IEMs) the poor audiophile's gateway drug. For the price, in-ears offer great audio quality, excellent portability without having to sell your kidney for partaking in some aural indulgence. As a result, IEMs as a category has seen a fair amount of consumer interest, especially this year thanks to smartphones and our ever price sensitive market. If you can deal with the snug fit and the idea of having transducers (albeit tiny ones) just inches away from your brain, the isolation offered by some models in this category is unmatched.

Zero1 Winner Brainwavz M3

Until recently these in-ears were the flagship headphones from Brainwavz. In terms of performance, we place the headphones at the top of the pile, suitable for almost any kind of music. The bass is fairly tight and impactful and the quantity is not too overwhelming. The sound signature is not bright and if were to put a label on it, we'd say it tends to sway to the warm side (mids accentuated) ever so slightly. One of the better sounding in-ears to enter our test centre and hence deservedly the winner of our Zero1 Award.

Worthy mentions Philips SHE 9750

For an odd-looking pair of headphones, the sound quality of the SHE 9750 is surprisingly good. Thanks to the gel-filled housing, the fit and isolation offered by the SHE 9750 is exceptional. At the same time unlike the closed sound of ear canal plugs these sound quite open. The bundled utilitarian hard case with built-in cable management is a bonus.

MEElectronics M6

The M6 is one of the most neutral sounding IEMs our weary ears had the pleasure of trying. The amount of bass is not distracting while the range is reproduced true to source. At a price of around ₹1,400 the M6 makes for a great purchase.